



says, "NCOSS is conceived of as an academic style conference, on a topic that has practical significance, with a specific focus on the application layer of open source."

Let's get started

When you have prominent personalities sharing their experiences, all you do is just sit back and listen. From workshop orientation, deploying FOSS applications, and sharing user experiences or case study details, it seemed like one action-packed thriller. (The only dilemma being what to attend—a lecture or a workshop?)

The keynote address by Prof C R Muthukrishnan on 'The Meaning, Purpose and Spirit of Open Source' was an eye-opener. The professor shared his experiences as a mentor to the OSS community. His mention of the software life cycle and the tension that sets in between the developers and the testing and marketing teams, struck a chord with the audience. According to the professor, quality control is a vital element in the success of any operating system and it all starts with the source code, notwithstanding the 'time to market' pressures. He further elaborated on interoperability issues, and was optimistic on how new phones in the market would make use of open standards. The keynote was followed by a talk by Dr Phatak, who enthralled the audience with his witty comments. Highlighting the success of 'Project Eklavya', he once again stressed upon the need for India's current role as a 'net-taker' to change to that of a 'net-giver' with respect to the worldwide open source community. Mind you, the fun had just begun.

Dr S Ramakrishnan, director general, C-DAC, offered his own insights on open source. He highlighted the role of OSS and how it was making inroads in many fields. "Open source software is maturing rapidly and different stakeholders in India are looking at it as a serious option for adoption. Government enterprises, the developer community, academia and users in different verticals have, in recent years, made specific moves towards adoption." And for that very reason, to keep the momentum going, NCOSS was initiated.

Inauguration session: (From left to right) George Arakal, Zia Saquib, Prof C R Muthukrishnan, Dr Deepak Phatak and Dr S Ramakrishnan

Zia Saquib, executive director, C-DAC, in his brief speech, complimented the various groups at C-DAC on their efforts in the localisation project, and how these were helping bridge the digital divide. Summing up the inaugural session was George Arakal, director administration, C-DAC, who mentioned the uniqueness of NCOSS and how privileged C-DAC was with the 'Trimurti' gracing the occasion. He was obviously referring to the presence of Dr Phatak, Prof Muthukrishnan, and Dr Ramakrishnan. That probably set the tone for the rest of the conference.

Knowledge redefined

After an exciting start, it was the round for interactive sessions. Parallel tracks on knowledge management, enterprise application, e-learning/e-commerce, along with thought-provoking demos, were highlights of the conference. Topics such as knowledge management systems using Joomla, node-oriented knowledge management, Blender 3D, and Moodle were just some of the sessions keeping the audience spellbound.

The talk on 'Rapid Scientific Application Development with Python' presented by Prof Prabhu Ramachandran, IIT Bombay, was simply amazing. Python is an ideal language for rapid application development in the scientific computing domain, and with several scientists in the audience, it was a session where everyone was able to connect instantly. The demo was interlaced with 2D and 3D graphics, based on GUIs related to aerospace engineering and particle systems, in the course of which Prof Ramachandran delighted the audience.

The other speaker who had been invited was Shuvam Misra, CEO, Merce Technologies, who spoke on 'Open source as one point on a continuum'. He took everyone down memory lane. C-News, BSD UNIX, the Linux kernel project, RHEL, Ubuntu, Debian, and MySQL, were all re-visited.